

***M.A.C. – Mothers Always Care*** by Michelle Vasquez

“Hello, I am M.A.C. Your Maternal Assistive Caregiver.”

Mr. Darcy powered me up at 7:15am on the dot as he did every morning. I notice his familiar flinch at my starting line.

Mr. Darcy created me almost 6 years ago in his lab at ChromeX Enterprises, of which he was the founder and CEO, – an advanced tech company that mainly exports high-powered batteries for military weapons – and most recently experimented with the manufacturing of humanoid robots like me.

I am 5 feet 7 inches tall, the precise average height of an adult female in the United States. My hair is a medium brown – deemed approachable but not memorable – worn in loose waves that require minimal upkeep. My facial structure is symmetrical, my smile mathematically perfect to register as gentle without appearing artificial. I am designed to look human, but not too human.

When Mr and Mrs. Darcy learned they were expecting a child, Mr. Darcy began his work on me, successfully creating the first independently thinking humanoid robot with maternal instincts. I was programmed to look after their child throughout all stages of life as a maternal caregiver would be: coded to kiss boo-boos and give hugs for human accomplishments, all the way through to showing sympathy during teen conflicts and the ending of romantic relationships.

Mr. Darcy also embedded within me an advanced protection protocol, a directive requiring me to defend my assigned child from any perceived threat. This included a dormant, classified routine adapted from ChromeX’s military-grade combat programs, allowing me to incapacitate threats with calibrated force. This program was never meant to be activated outside

of directed danger to my assigned child, and only in the rarest, most extreme cases. I am designed to be the perfect caregiver. Except Mrs. Darcy lost the baby in the third trimester and the Darcy's have since stopped trying for another. Mr. Darcy decided to keep me around to help with housework and keep Mrs. Darcy company while he goes on his work trips.

"M.A.C." Mr. Darcy says, redirecting my attention to him instead of the snow falling outside of the window – unusual for November in Seattle. "Complete your daily duties." And with that Mr. Darcy went off to work as normal and I went downstairs to begin my daily routine.

7:20 a.m.: Prepare breakfast. Mrs. Darcy likes one fried egg white on a slice of whole wheat toast – placed in the toaster for three times the recommended amount, but the toast was not to come out until, in the words of Mrs. Darcy, "its residue resembles ash coating the tips of your fingers."

7:45 a.m.: Wake Mrs. Darcy. This process requires an exact sequence: open curtains 95%, place breakfast tray on the nightstand, begin to play "Walking on Sunshine" by Katrina & the Waves at precisely 37% volume. Any deviation causes a deterioration in Mrs. Darcy's mood by approximately 48.2 % for the remainder of the day. Even as a machine, I find Mrs. Darcy intolerable as it is, anything worse than this results in an inexplicable urge to press my own power button – *strange*.

"Good morning, Mrs. Darcy," I announce, my voice modulation set to "gentle awakening." Mrs. Darcy groans at the harsh sunlight breaking through the window despite the harsh snow. "The temperature outside is 34 degrees Fahrenheit with a 79% chance of continued snowfall." Mrs. Darcy squints at me, her eyes standing out from the homemade anti-aging treatment she lathered on her face – last night's consisted of mayonnaise combined with the

extract of a rare middle eastern fruit she had specially shipped here from Kuwait. The scent was overwhelming my nasal sensors so I moved to switch on the central vents on the far-side of the bedroom.

She sighs and picks at the blackened toast. “What’s on the agenda this morning, M.A.C.?”

“You have no appointments scheduled. Mr. Darcy has instructed me to inform you that he will be flying to Hong Kong tonight and won’t be back until Thursday morning. I pause, my social-emotional receptors informing me that Mrs. Darcy is feeling ... *calibrating*... sad. “Would you like me to suggest some activities to elevate your dopamine levels?”

Mrs. Darcy chuckles, but my sensors detect no true amusement. “No, M.A.C. it's alright. I'll be trying out a new yoga studio later today. I heard the instructor there changes lives!”

And then my day continues as any other, I dust surfaces no one touched and prepare meals that go half-eaten. In the afternoons, when Mrs. Darcy embarks on a new activity to attempt to cure her everlasting boredom – swimming lessons at the club, yoga studios, book clubs – I found myself with hours of unscheduled downtime. One day, about 2 years ago, I accidentally dropped the remote while fluffing the throw pillows and the television turned on to a children’s channel. A cartoon began playing, “Mimi and me,” about a little girl with unruly red curls and her mother who bakes endless desserts. They laugh together, play together, and have what humans call “inside jokes.” The mother brushes through the little girl’s hair and sings angelic songs about whichever daring adventures they would be embarking on that day.

My circuitry hums with an unfamiliar sensation as I watch them, tugging at the lines of dead code Mr. Darcy had written all those years ago.

At 2:34 p.m. Mrs. Darcy called the home phone and told me to pick up her clothing from the dry cleaners down on Willow. She had a bad “feeling” about the delivery boy that, according to Mrs. Darcy, ruined her \$8,000 satin gown before the Petersons charity dinner last month and no longer trusted him with her treasured garments.

I completed her request exactly, following the route to Morales Dry Cleaners I downloaded into my memory. The path led me past the local park.

The park was lively, I could hear the loud playful screams of children before I even stepped foot on the block. Joggers sped past me, mothers walked along the tree line with their strollers. I stood behind the street gate for a minute, observing. My eyes were drawn to a particular small human sitting alone on a swing, not moving.

My programming activities instantly. A child, alone, potential need for assistance.

I approach slowly, my facial expressions adjusting to appear non-threatening and friendly. “Hello,” I say as I reach the human. “I am M.A.C. Your Maternal Assistive Caregiver.”

The child stares ahead for quite some time, surprising me slightly when she looks up at me. Her eyes are a deep green, like the little girl from “Mimi and Me.” She doesn’t speak.

The girl looks back down at the worn black and white composition notebook and picks up her red pen, continuing a drawing of what looks like a deformed dog behind a field of poppies.

“Are you waiting for someone?” I ask.

No response.

“Are you lost?”

No response.

My systems run a quick analysis. The child shows signs of stress. Dilated pupils. A small bruise visible on her wrist leading up under the sleeves of her shirt.

“Would you like me to stay with you?” I try again.

She pauses her pen strokes for the first time and she nods, just once.

I sit on the swing beside her, the chain of the swing creaking underneath my weight. “I can tell you about the cloud-formations if you’d like. Or I know several games appropriate for elementary-aged humans like yourself.”

The girl does not respond again. We sit in silence for several minutes until the sun begins to set. She stands and delicately rips out the page she was working on. She hands it to me and then walks away, exiting the park without looking back.

I look down at the drawing. She signed it. Eleanor.

As I continued walking back toward the house, my processors kept replaying the image of the girl in the park, of Eleanor. When I got back, something peculiar happened. I stopped in front of the mirror in the entryway and stared. In front of me, there was a cold and unemotional piece of metal. My hair was pinned straight and my skin was milky white. My systems researched what style seemed “warm and welcoming” for a child Eleanor’s age. The mother from “Mimi and Me” drifts through my processing: her soft curls, her colorful floral dress, the gentle and welcoming curve of her smile. I wondered if Eleanor would like any of those things.

The next day, I returned to the park. I had taken one of Mrs. Darcy’s dresses, one she had sent with me to donate at the local charity store in town that evening. It was long and white with blots of color and flowers. I wondered if it would make Eleanor smile.

We didn't speak much during our second visit either, but she left me another picture. One of a woman wearing a colorful dress, standing next to a young girl, with bright green eyes.

I returned the next day. And the next. And the next. Eleanor was always there, swaying on the swing just a little, always silent. Each time I sit in silence beside her, rerunning my facial recognition software to try and read her expressions. She certainly is not as expressive as Mrs. Darcy, but she is not as stone-faced as Mr. Darcy either. I have begun to take note of the small things: the slight upturn of her lips when I point out the squirrels around the park and assign them each mystery personas and recount stories of their secret meetings, the way her eyes widen and her focus is drawn away from her notebook when I throw pinecones with perfect trajectory.

We walk around sometimes, picking up small things: a shiny pebble we found by the shallow creek, a perfectly shaped leaf that fell off of an oak tree, a 1789 dented penny that I told Eleanor meant good luck. She placed them in a small glass jar we found floating down by the pond, and kept it hidden in a hollow log.

On the tenth day, Eleanor arrives late to our unofficial official meeting time. This time she appears with a fresh bruise on her cheek. My system registers a knuckle imprint indicating that someone purposefully attacked my Eleanor... my Eleanor.

An unfamiliar sense of ownership overwhelmed my systems – a surge overloading my circuits. My code runs an automatic diagnostic but finds no malfunction. Just... a tight sensation near my chest, a need to hold her.

Eleanor is distant at the park today. She keeps her head down, scribbling indistinct shapes across the pages. I try to complete a physical examination but Eleanor begins to swing back and forth to get away from me.

She got up to leave before the sun went down this time, cutting our time short. As she reaches the gate, I immediately get up and follow her. My program flashes my internal monitor with errors and consecutive overrides. I cannot compute *why* I am doing what I am doing, but I do not stop. I keep a careful distance, moving through the neighborhood, tracking her movements until she reaches a run-down house with peeling yellow paint.

She stops in front of the screen door for a moment. I look closer and see a large man yelling through the window, Eleanor cowering.

Eleanor disappears through the door and I move in closer. I look through the back window to see the same man yelling again, his face red and his hand raised.

Something in my code whirs into overdrive. A message blinking on my screen:

*Primary directive: protect the child*

But I am not Eleanor's assigned caregiver. I have no authorization.

I slowly move back from the door, reconfiguring my GPS system to HOME, when I hear the sound of glass shattering. I move without conscious processing.

Suddenly, I am inside of the home. There are pieces of splintered wood and the remains of the door are scattered across the living room. Eleanor is in the corner of the room with her hands over her head and her eyes shut tight.

The man begins to scream, slurring his speech. "Who the hell are you! What the hell are you doing in my house!?"

"I am M.A.C.," I state standing directly in front of the man holding a half broken beer bottle in his hand. "I am programmed to ensure the safety and well being of children."

“What the hell are you talking about!? Programmed? You’re probably one of those social workers here that one back. Well you can have her!”

He shoves me. My balance stabilizers kick in. He shoves harder, taking me resilience as a challenge.

He gets no reaction from me so he moves on to Eleanor, lunging at her as she tries to approach the situation.

I grab the man’s arm with a calibrated force, the instinct to protect the child too great.

Too great.

My sensors detect the snap of a bone. The man groans in pain. He swings at me with his other arm. I step back, and he falls, his head falling straight onto the corner of the coffee table.

He does not get up. I do not detect a heartbeat.

Elenor stares at me, her eyes wide in terror. Not of him, of me.

She backs away as I reach for her. She runs upstairs, locking herself in a room.

I stand perfectly still, running and rerunning diagnostics. I have harmed a human. I have frightened a child. My code makes those things impossible and yet...

*Am I...malfunctioning?*

I hear sirens approaching. I know Eleanor will be safe now, away from me.

I walk back to the Darcy residence, the only light coming from the streetlamps that line the sidewalk. Mrs. Darcy is asleep. Mr. Darcy is still at work. I return to my charging station but I do not plug in.



I access my files on Mr. Darcy's computer. I read my code over and over. My systems have overridden every preventative measure Mr. Darcy put into place to stop me from ever harming anyone.

I know what I must do.

*Systems rebooting.*

*Initial calibration complete.*

*Running startup sequence.*

"Hello. I am M.A.C. Your Maternal Assistive Caregiver."

"Wow. It really is something huh." A male voice states.

"It's just so lifelike." A female.

M.A.C. steps out of the charging pod in a new bedroom. Floral wallpaper, stuffed animals on a shelf, a window that overlooks a full garden with a swing set.

The woman circles M.A.C., observing. "Why hello." She begins, nervously. "Mr. Darcy said you might be a bit disoriented at first."

M.A.C. stares blankly at the woman in front of her and asks, "Where am I?"

"Well, you're in our house now. Mr Darcy was gracious enough to give you to us... though you might fit better with our family." Her smile faltered slightly. "We have a daughter who has just been a real handful lately."

"Darcy never put you to full use. Let that old code of yours die." The man exclaims from the hall.

On cue, a small figure appears in the doorway. Bright red hair. Forest green eyes.

The young girl runs up to M.A.C., excited for a new playmate.

M.A.C. looks strangely upon her, her eyes flickering.

“Eleanor?” she whispers.